

A LIFE OF LEISURE

The early 1900s was a time of contradiction: on the one hand was rapid technological change, the rise of motor cars, and female emancipation; on the other, a golden glow of romantic, hedonistic nostalgia enjoyed by the leisured classes. The latter view still defines the Edwardian era for many, and it was captured perfectly by contemporary fashions.

Edward VII's love of extravagant pleasure set the age's tone, with rounds of lavish balls, country-house parties, travel, and sporting pursuits. England's expanding middle classes, upwardly mobile due to the Industrial Revolution, aped this upper-class lifestyle: garden parties, tea on the terrace, picnics, regattas, the races – all requiring suitable outfits. For women, pastel colours were de rigueur, as was sumptuous lace, *mousseline de soie* (gauze-like fabric), silk chiffon, tulle, crêpe de Chine, ribbon trimmings, and any frilly, lacy detailing. Huge hats bobbed with great feathers or silk flowers. Long, wavy hair was fastened around pads for luxuriant fullness, and the parasol was an essential accessory. The fashionable female shape, created by corsetry, was also luxuriant: a large, low, forward-thrust “monobosom”, a wasp waist, and full hips from which a bell-shaped skirt, narrower than Victorian styles, fell gracefully. High necks and long sleeves were worn in daytime, with bodices and necklines infilled with lace or light fabric. Male fashions served as a simple, sober foil. Frock and morning coats were joined by lounge suits worn with crisp collar and cuffs, hats, and umbrella or cane.

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Society tottered through the last of the pre-War parties, waved tiny lace handkerchiefs, and carried elaborate parasols until the War came with its sweeping changes.

LUCILE, LADY DUFF GORDON, LEADING EDWARDIAN-ERA LONDON COUTURIER, IN HER MEMOIRS, *DISCRETIONS AND INDISCRETIONS*, 1932

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FASHIONABLE PURSUITS ▷

The man's binocular case suggests these Edwardians are at the races. Ascot, Derby, Longchamps, and Auteuil almost served as catwalks and the less well-to-do went to these racecourses not only to bet but also to gawp.

